Little Brain Crew

FREE PRINTABLE

For parents of kids 3–17

15 ways to end screen time without tears



WHY THE TEARS COME

Apps and shows hand out quick, easy rewards, and most have no natural finish line. When the screen goes dark, Dopa (our cartoon for the brain's "want more" messenger) suddenly loses its easy stars. Nothing is wrong with your kid. The ending just needs a plan.



Step 1

Before the screen goes on

1 Set the ending before it starts

An ending agreed in advance isn't a surprise.

"Two episodes, then we turn it off together."

2 Pick a finish line

An episode, a level, a song. Not a feed. Turn autoplay off so the next video doesn't start by itself.

3 Use a timer they can see

A kitchen timer or a sand timer next to the screen. The timer ends it, not you.

4 Agree where you land next

A snack, a small job, a game outside. Going to something is easier than leaving something.

"When the timer rings, we're making popcorn."



Step 2

When it's time to stop

5

Warn twice

At 5 minutes and at 1 minute. Some families use 10 and 2. Pick one and keep it.

"Five more minutes, then the screen goes to sleep."

6

Break the spell first

Touch a shoulder and wait for eye contact before you say anything. Words don't reach a kid who's still inside the screen.

7

Offer a small choice

A choice gives back a little control.

"Do you want to turn it off, or should I?"

8

Name the feeling, keep the limit

Feelings are allowed. The limit stays.

"Two things are true: screen time is over, and you're allowed to be upset."

9

Say less

One short sentence, repeated, in a calm voice. No lecture while feelings are big. Stay close.

10

Don't give it back to stop the crying

And don't debate a rule you've already set. Pushback often fades within a week or two of steady endings.



Step 3

Around the day

11

Same ending, every day

Same time, same words, same next step. Kids handle limits better when they can predict them.

12

Screens off about an hour before bed

Bright light in the evening can push sleepiness later, even in young kids. Dim lamps instead.

13

Devices sleep outside the bedroom

Phones and tablets charge in the kitchen overnight. Parents' too.

14

Make an "instead" list together

Ten things to do that aren't screens, written by your kid, on the fridge. Start yours on the next page.

15

Go first

Put your own phone away at meals and when screen time ends. With teens, make a deal, not a rule: write a family screen plan together.

"Phones in the basket, mine first."

Tip 14 · write it together

Our "instead" list



Ten things to do that aren't screens. Your child writes or draws them, and it goes on the fridge next to the screen.

1	_____	**2**	_____
3	_____	**4**	_____
5	_____	**6**	_____
7	_____	**8**	_____
9	_____	**10**	_____

Ideas: build a den · bake something · draw a comic · board game · bike or scooter · dance party · play outside · Lego · read a comic · help cook dinner

+ WHEN TO TALK TO YOUR PEDIATRICIAN

If screens crowd out sleep, school, friends or family life even with steady limits, or if screen time comes with big mood changes.



Want the full plan? The Kid Brain Toolkit and The 30-Day Reset turn this into one small habit a day, with the exact words for every age. **littlebraincrew.com**

PLEASE READ

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